Sèrie 0.1

Reading comprehension (text setembre 2024)

WHAT YOUR JEANS CAN (AND DO) HIDE

Paris, Milan, New York… These are some of the world's most prestigious fashion **catwalks**. There, young women and men graciously parade to impress elite guests and TV watchers with the surprising, fabulous creativity of the most renowned fashion designers. Yet, regardless of the amazing costs of such shows, there is a hidden price that Mother Nature pays (and which is not included in the price tag).

Let's start with the case of innocent blue jeans: it takes around 7,500 litres of water to make just one single pair. Know what this means? It is equivalent to the amount of water the average person drinks over a period of seven years. That's just one of the many startling facts that emerge from recent environmental research, and which show the real cost of staying fashionable.

When we think of industries that have a harmful effect on the environment, manufacturing, energy, transport and even food production come to mind. But the fashion industry is considered by the UN Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD) to be the second most polluting industry in the world. In fact, according to UNCTAD, some 93 billion cubic metres of water — enough to meet the needs of five million people — are used by the fashion industry annually, and around half a million tons of microfibre, which is the equivalent of 3 million barrels of oil, are now being dumped into the ocean every year.

As for carbon emissions, the industry is responsible for more than all international flights and maritime shipping combined. "The dominant business model in the sector is that of 'fast fashion', whereby consumers are offered constantly changing collections at low prices, and encouraged to frequently buy and discard clothes, "UNCTAD further explains. And it warns that the trend is responsible for "a plethora of negative social, economic and environmental impacts and, with clothing production doubling between 2000 and 2014, it is crucially important to ensure that clothes are produced as ethically and sustainably as possible."

For its part, UN Environment provides more conservative figures. It says that considering cotton production, manufacture, transport and washing, it takes 3,781 litres of water to make one pair of jeans. Furthermore, the process equates to around 33.4 kilograms of carbon equivalent emitted, like driving 111 kilometres or watching 246 hours of TV on a big screen. Even just washing our clothes releases plastic microfibers and other pollutants into the environment, contaminating our oceans and drinking water, and entering the food chain, UN Environment warns, and adds that around 20% of global industrial water pollution is from **dyeing** and textile treatment.

Some studies estimate that the average garment is now worn ten times before being discarded. Demand for clothing is projected to rise 2% a year—but the number of times we wear a garment has dropped by half compared to the early 2000s. This waste costs money and the value of natural resources. Of the total fibre input used for clothing, 87% is incinerated or sent to **landfill**. Overall, one garbage truck of textiles is landfilled or incinerated every second. The issue is so alarming that 10 different UN organisations joined forces through an Alliance for Sustainable Fashion, which seeks to halt the environmentally and socially destructive practices of fashion. Elisa Tonda, from UN Environment, explained this urgency: "The global production of clothing and footwear generates 8% of the world's greenhouse gas emissions and, with manufacturing concentrated in Asia, the industry is mainly reliant on hard coal and natural gas to generate electricity. If we carry on with a business-as-usual approach, the greenhouse gas emissions from the industry will rise by almost 50 % by 2030."

Fashion today is about obsession with outward image and appearance. Rarely do we as consumers consider what's on the inside: the environmental cost. Now that we know, who will dare to take the bull by the horn?

catwalk: passarel·la / pasarela
dye: tenyir / teñir
landfill: abocador / vertedero

Text adapted from an article by Baher Kamal. *Meer* [online] (1April, 2019)

Reading comprehension

Answer the questions below using complete sentences. Each question is worth 0.5 points with a total of 3 points. Up to 0.3 points might be deducted from the total mark for lack of intelligibility in the answers provided. You may use fragments from the text unless specified not to do so.

1. **Why is the fashion industry considered the second most polluting industry in the world? PLEASE MENTION <u>TWO</u> REASONS.**

2. **Complete the following sentence:**
   According to the UN Environment, making one pair of jeans…

3. **According to the text, how often do consumers tend to discard clothes now as compared to the early 2000s? DO NOT COPY FROM THE TEXT.**

4. **What is the *Alliance for Sustainable Fashion* and what is its main objective?**

5. **Rewrite the following sentence from the text in your own words:**
   Rarely do we as consumers consider what's on the inside: the environmental cost.
   You may keep grammatical words (i.e. the, to, most, etc.) and the following words / phrases in your sentence.

6. **Find an expression in the text that means the following: "aim to stop"**

Writing

Choose ONE topic. Your answer should be 125-150 words in length. There is no specific penalty for exceeding 150 words in length. Extra points are not given for exceeding 150 words.

1. Imagine you are contributing to your school website, which is read by your classmates, teachers, and even students from other schools and you've been asked to write a review of a social network to be published on the website. Social networks are everywhere, and you are probably a regular user of at least one of them. For this assignment, select your favourite social network platform where you engage the most and write a review of it. In your review, include aspects such as overall user experience, specific features, content quality, community engagement, or any other aspect that stands out to you. Your goal is to provide a thorough and engaging review that will be informative and interesting for other teenagers who might be considering using this platform.

2. These days, teenagers participate in many extracurricular activities such as sports, foreign languages, arts and crafts, or music alongside their academic commitments. The local newspaper has asked you to write a **for-and-against essay** discussing the potential benefits and downsides of participating in extracurricular activities. Consider the various reasons why students engage in these activities and evaluate both the positive and negative aspects. This is an opportunity to reflect on your own experience and share insights that could help others balance their academic and extracurricular commitments.